CONTRADANCE

Screenplay, v3
(WITH TREATMENT INSERTS)

Story by
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Started: JUNE 17 2026, LONDON, UK
Draft v3 Completed: AUGUST 30, 2026, VANCOUVER, BC

ACT I - THE STUDIO

1 INT. THOMAS' STUDIO - DAY

Over black. A Super8 camera and projector are set down, then wind and whirr to life.

A desk is strewn with camera lenses, string, puppets, felt, wood and power tools. Amongst the incoherent mess of an artist's workspace sits Walt Whitman's *Leaves of Grass*.

SASHA (F, 28) leans back on a chair in the corner of the studio. A few beats.

THOMAS
Sasha, can you give me a hand?

She stands and walks to THOMAS' (M, 28) desk. She helps him tinker with the projector. It clicks on and starts rolling.

Thomas pumps his fist excitedly and runs off to the video camera. Having forgotten to thank Sasha, he backtracks to give her a kiss on the forehead.

Sasha returns to her seat in the corner.

2 INT. STOP MOTION SET - MOMENTS LATER

Through the Super8 camera, a felt boat bobs across a papier maché ocean. It's movements are jerky, repeatedly moved a fraction of an inch by Thomas' hand.

BEGIN FLASHBACK: INT. FERRY - DAY

Thomas sits in a ferry's window seat while the background changes behind him.

Through the window, the New York Harbour comes and goes. Rather than taking in the view, Thomas cranes his neck to see the front of the ferry.

3 INT. TRAIN - DAY

Thomas sits in the train's window seat, the background still changing.

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European landscapes come and go through the window, while Thomas still cranes his neck towards the front of the train, paying little mind to the changing sights.

Eventually, the train's window looks onto Russia, shortly post-Soviet Union. It slows to a stop.

Thomas finally takes in the landscape, then looks over the items in the leather briefcase open on the seat beside him. Notebooks, pens, a portable tape recorder and a press credential.

He flips open one of the notebooks and takes out a slip of loose paper: a folded up newspaper article with a photo of engineers working on a rocket.

The title reads "BURAN ENGINEERS LET GO DUE TO PROGRAMME CANCELLATION."

4 EXT. TRAIN STATION - DAY

Thomas exits the train, still looking at the newspaper article. In the picture, a woman's face is clearly discernible.

Thomas holds the picture up in front of him, his focus on that woman.

When he lowers the picture, Sasha is standing in front of him, the woman in the picture.

They shake hands.

THOMAS
(pointing to himself)
Thomas.

Sasha nods. Spotting the newspaper in his hand, she points at herself in the picture.

SASHA
(giggling)
Sasha.

They shake hands. Entranced, Thomas holds on to her hand for slightly longer than he should.

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Finally letting go, he scrambles to open his briefcase and pull out his recorder.

He shakes Sasha's hand once more, having forgotten in his hurry that they'd already moved through this formality once.

START OF MONTAGE: SASHA AND THOMAS' INTERVIEW

5 EXT. SIDEWALK - DAY

Walking together, Thomas starts up his recorder. Sasha looks around nervously.

THOMAS
Are you okay being recorded?

Sasha chews on her lip, deciding.

THOMAS (CONT'D)
It's just for quotes.. And I won't publish anything you aren't comfortable with.

She finally nods, but pulls his sleeve over the recorder for discretion.

SASHA
(speaking into his floppy sleeve)
It was a good decade to be in the business of rockets.

START OF FLASHBACK

6 INT. SOVIET SPACE CENTRE - DAY

A group of engineers work on the Buran. Plans are spread over tables while others weld.

SASHA (V.O.)
I was on the Buran project. Lucky me, back then... It was to be very grand. The first rocket that could exit the Earth and come back, again and again. And it did! Once. And then the project... done.

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END OF FLASHBACK

7 EXT. SIDEWALK - DAY

THOMAS
What happened to the people?

SASHA
The people?

THOMAS
The engineers.

8 EXT. PARK - DAY

Sasha and Thomas continue chatting beneath a tree, sitting close together. The tape recorder is on the ground next to Thomas.

Sasha pulls his loose shirt over it to cover it.

SASHA
Set free and diluted into the rest of Russia, if that's what you're asking.

THOMAS
(cheekily)
What about state secrets?

Sasha pretends to zip her mouth shut and throw away the key. She teases unzipping her mouth, then motions that she's only joking.

Thomas clicks the tape recorder off and inches closer.

THOMAS (CONT'D)
(gently tapping on her temple)
What about all the stuff up here?
The non-classified bits.

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9 EXT. IN FRONT OF THE MOTHERLAND CALLS - DAY

SASHA
The stuff up here's not all wasted.
I keep busy with my project.

THOMAS
Your project?

10 EXT. SASHA'S MEADOW - DAY

Sasha brings Thomas to a strange structure of half-mangled salvaged parts.

SASHA
My project.

Holding out a sketchbook, she points between her old drawings and the propulsion system in the works.

Thomas unclasps his briefcase and pulls out his camera.

Sasha is startled and stands between Thomas and the propulsion system.

SASHA (CONT'D)
No! This cannot go in your article.

Thomas lowers it in confusion.

THOMAS
(casually)
Why not?

SASHA
Because they'll find it and take it.

THOMAS
They? Who's 'they'?

SASHA
They, Russia.

THOMAS
But it's *your* project.

She taps her temple as he had in earlier conversations.

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SASHA
There is little up here that is not classified.

Thomas laughs. She is ever so slightly taken aback, as though she hadn't meant to make a joke, but is rather happy that it landed anyhow.

THOMAS
I hear ya. What if I promise the pictures are for my memories? Not the article.

Sasha thinks for a moment.

SASHA
Promise?

THOMAS
Promise.

They shake on it. Sasha goes in for a second handshake, mocking the accidental second one Thomas initiated at the train station. He laughs.

THOMAS (CONT'D)
You tease me!

Sasha laughs too. Thomas lays down in the field and smiles up at her. He kicks off his shoes.

THOMAS (CONT'D)
Well since I'm off the clock, you don't mind if I make myself at home, do ya?

Sasha gives him an inquisitive look. She finds him, and his imposing presence, strange but intriguing.

She shrugs and lays down too. She keeps her eyes on the sky, but he doesn't take his eyes off of her.

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ACT II - THE MEADOW

11 EXT. SASHA'S MEADOW - DAY

Some time has passed. Sasha works on her propulsion system in the meadow as Thomas watches. He starts getting restless, sighing loudly.

SASHA
Hm?

Thomas shrugs.

THOMAS
I'm jealous!

SASHA
(smiling)
Of who? Me?

THOMAS
Yeah, you. I'm not making anything cool like that.

SASHA
Well, help me then. You can hold the plans.

THOMAS
Bah, I'm no use. There's not a classified speck in these rugged hands.

He presents some pretty soft paws.

Sasha laughs, and stops working for a second. She looks towards the house, thinking.

SASHA
I've got craft supplies if you want to keep busy. No calluses required.

Thomas considers her offer, and seems pleased by the thought.

THOMAS
I could make a movie.

Sasha shrugs, happy to get back to work.

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12 INT. THE STUDIO - DAY

On the desk, the early bones of a stop motion set are starting to take shape. The design is incoherent and nondescript.

Thomas looks out the window, and sees Sasha making good progress on her propulsion system.

He looks back at his stop motion set, unimpressed with himself.

Sitting in front of it, and cocks his head to look at it from another angle.

13 EXT. MEADOW - DAY

Sasha grabs a bike tilted against the house, and rides off.

14 EXT. MARKET - DAY

She parks her bike near a produce stand, and purchases a few fruits and vegetables.

She plops her loot in the bike's front basket, and sets off again.

15 EXT. OLD ORTHODOX CATHEDRAL - DAY

Sasha gets off her bike and leans it against the cathedral's wall.

She walks to the cathedral's entrance and pushes open its heavy doors with both hands.

16 INT. OLD ORTHODOX CATHEDRAL - DAY

Sasha walks down a few rows of the empty cathedral's pews before sitting down on one of them. She looks up at the stained glass.

She rises, and walks toward the window sill. She traces the wood.

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Suddenly, she grabs at the wood and tries to shake it loose. A small piece comes off.

She looks at the piece for a second, then tries to put it back by balancing it into place.

17 INT. THE STUDIO

Thomas ruffles through clutter in his new studio space. Undeveloped negatives are bunched on the desk, and half-made models populate the stop motion set.

He picks up a pen and notebook and scribbles for a while. After a few beats he looks up while still scribbling at the same pace.

An inky, stringy blob is revealed on the open page.

Thomas paces around his studio, eyeing the clutter.

He stops above his stop motion set, and shifts one of the structures on it to the right. Then to the left. And the right again.

He sits back at his desk, looking irritated and ashamed at his lack of creative output.

He wanders out of the studio.

18 EXT. MEADOW - DAY

Thomas lays flat in the grass. Next to him is a basket with a trowel and a humble selection of gardening utensils.

Beside him, a flower pot is tipped over, laying the small tree it contained on its side. It's roots are still bound in plastic. The dirt beneath it is frosty and inhospitable.

Off-screen, the rattling of a bicycle is heard.

Sasha emerges on her bike, a few letters and the market's produce still in her basket.

Silently, without urgency, she sets her bike down and sighs.

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SASHA
(gesturing to the tree)
I was gone for hours, Thomas. I asked you to plant this.

THOMAS
I can't do it.

SASHA
I noticed.

THOMAS
I can't do anything.

SASHA
Well I wouldn't say-

THOMAS
(interrupting her)
All the time I've spent in this empty country and I haven't been able to make a thing to show for it. Not the article, not the film. It used to be easy, and I can't do it anymore. I woke up one day it was just gone.

Sasha gestures towards him. Thomas passes her the trowel, stands up, and holds the tree as she pats it into the ground expertly.

THOMAS (CONT'D)
I lost my-

SASHA
(sarcastically)
Well, get it back, then.

THOMAS
It's not that simple. The magic's gone.

SASHA
It doesn't take magic, it's just a tree.

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THOMAS
I’m not talking about the tree. How do you get up every day and just build this rocket? I used to be that way, but I chased it as far as it would go, and then I couldn’t even remember how I used to do it.

SASHA
(teasing)
You used to build rockets?

He glares at her.

SASHA (CONT'D)
(more earnestly)
Happens. You just pick it up and do it again.

THOMAS
And it comes back when you do?

SASHA
Or it doesn't. You can't force the math, so you go on a walk.

THOMAS
What's a walk got to do with anything?

SASHA
A lot.

Thomas looks at her, perplexed.

SASHA (CONT'D)
You can't argue it back. You have to go be useful somewhere else and and let it come back to you when it's ready.

THOMAS
(in his own world)
I miss living inside of what I'd made, after. I used to build these little worlds, and for a while I'd just stay there. And then I'd look up from the camera and I'd be here again.
(MORE)

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THOMAS (CONT'D)
It's the worst part of waking up. Not that the dream ends. That you have to come back to something so much smaller.

SASHA
You dream people always think it left because you did something wrong. It's not that interested in you.

THOMAS
I don't believe that.

A long beat.

SASHA
Rocket or film, you suffer for it sometimes. Now get up, God's sake.

Something stirs in Thomas. He doesn’t respond.

He gets up, wanders over to her bike, and starts going through the mail in Sasha’s bike basket as she continues working on the tree.

Among the envelopes, he finds an evangelist card. He turns it toward Sasha.

THOMAS
What does this say?

SASHA
'Вы знаете Бога?'

THOMAS
What does that mean?

SASHA
'Do you know God?'

Thomas chuckles. He starts monologuing, looking in Sasha's direction without necessarily addressing her.

THOMAS
God? Hah, do I know God! They say in the beginning, there was the Word. And the Word was with God. Actually, it was God.
(MORE)

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THOMAS (CONT'D)
To me, though, it's nothing but ash and bone. What are beginnings? Nothing, man, nothing. Empty, scratch. Just waiting. A lot of waiting. Waiting for something to start. You can wait and wait and wait and your whole life will just pass you by. It's grey, man. It's boring. It's exhausting.

Sasha continues to plant the tree, silent and content on the backdrop of his ramblings.

THOMAS (CONT'D)
But look at this light, man!

He spins around.

THOMAS (CONT'D)
It just hits you. And golden golds, glimmering and glowing. Sasha, I saw all this light and glass… and colours, oh, so many colours, you can't even imagine. Technicolour reds and grainy, stocky greens… and blues and yellows, saturated and bleeding. Astronomical. And miraculous. Holy, holy, holy.

Thomas runs under the tree with Sasha. She glances at him briefly, then goes back to planting.

THOMAS (CONT'D)
In the beginning, there was a tree like this one, or so they tell me. Whole, and singular. Untroubled by any alternatives you could think of or devise. It was just a tree, an apple tree. Come spring or winter or whenever harvest season is—

SASHA
October.

THOMAS
—apples, apples, so many apples. Rose-coloured red apples would just fall from its branches into the greenest of green grass.
(MORE)

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THOMAS (CONT'D)
Yeah, that's God man. That's the Word. So, do I know God! I know him very well. I see him everyday. His tree was just a simple apple tree. It didn't have a choice what kind of tree it wanted to be, how many apples it wanted to sprout, how many places it wanted to be. It just was, and it was beautiful.

A beat.

THOMAS (CONT'D)
I wish I could be that simple. Have that kind of choice made for me. But this is my tree, and I don't even know what kind of tree it is.

SASHA
It's an apple tree.

THOMAS
The half-dead tree in my mother's yard in Toronto that fruits every September out of spite more than health. The tree outside my apartment in London that the council keeps fining my landlord for because it won't stop dropping apples everywhere and he won't do fuck all to clean them up. And, oh, that time in Brooklyn, a whole ways away from the city, that one street with the apple trees so big they formed this canopy over the road, stretching branches and branches and branches of the most amazing apples you can imagine. But I'm one man, with only one stomach. If I could eat 'em all maybe they could come with me.

A beat. Thomas is getting emotional.

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THOMAS (CONT'D)
And then it's just me, and the sky laughs at me as I look for the one patch of earth that'll absolve me of every other patch I got too full to eat from. I don't even know what kind of tree this is.

SASHA
It's an apple tree.

A beat.

THOMAS
None of it ever felt like ash and bone until I had to actually put my hands in the dirt and admit that I'd chosen.

Thomas runs over and puts his hands on her shoulders.

THOMAS (CONT'D)
This is the one, though, this flat, impossible nothingness of a country. You, Sasha, don't need the Word to be God. You just need the ground to hold. That's what I love about you. Here, in Russia, we will stay, for good.

Sasha finishes planting the tree. She stands up.

SASHA
It is finished.

THOMAS
I love you, Sasha.

She stirs slightly, like she’s embarrassed someone will hear them. She walks away, and Thomas watches her go.

Impulsively, he raises his camera to capture her retreating back.

Suddenly, he stops himself and lowers the camera. He stands beneath the tree alone for a moment, watching Sasha gain ground away from him.

He sets the camera down in the grass and walks after her.

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She hears his footsteps and slows without stopping. He catches up and walks beside her in silence.

She looks at him and smiles slightly, then lets him take her hand.

They walk towards the house together, leaving the camera behind, under the tree.

19 INT. THOMAS' STUDIO - EVENING

In the same messy workspace, Thomas picks up a single piece of scrap felt.

He starts cutting it into a rough shape, holding it gruffly. The shape is insignificant but he trudges on, cutting more pieces.

Hours of work follow: hands working, felt and glue and wire, small bouts of progress accumulating.

A little felt figure takes shape. Thomas sits back for a second and examines what he's made.

START OF FLASHBACK

20 EXT. SASHA'S MEADOW - DAY

Hovering over Thomas, Sasha plants the tree.

SASHA
(flatly)
It's an apple tree.

END OF FLASHBACK

He looks at the felt figurine in his hand. For the first time, his expression's top note is hope, rather than crisis.

THOMAS
(with reverence)
Sasha.

He moves her little felt hand side to side, waving back.

He starts building a new stop motion set: a painted meadow, with a pile of aluminium pieces at its centre.

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ACT III - THE BURAN

21 INT. THOMAS' STUDIO - DAY

Thomas keeps working on the film, building felt models and piecing together a dollhouse.

22 EXT. SASHA'S MEADOW - DAY

Sasha continues working on her rocket ship.

23 INT. THOMAS' STUDIO - DAY

Silhouettes behind a projector: Sasha walks up behind Thomas and gives him a hug. He grabs her arm, she kisses him on the head then exits the frame. He keeps working.

From above, Thomas' hands keep gluing, building, fixing his camera, loading film, adjusting lights.

24 EXT. SASHA'S MEADOW - DAY

From above, Sasha's blackened hands adjust bolts and wield various tools.

25 INT. THE STOP-MOTION SET - DAY

The felt model of Sasha is in a hangar, working on building a large aerospace project, a nondescript vessel that resembles a rocket but could just as easily be a missile.

The felt model of Thomas films her.

In the background the stop motion background changes from day to night.

26 INT. THE STOP-MOTION SET - NIGHT

The felt models return home together, wandering beneath a papier maché night sky.

The pair stands by a moonlight ocean, looking out at the horizon together.

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27 INT. BEDROOM - DAY

Sasha sifts through her closet and pulls out her only sundress.

She pulls it over the head, and admires her reflection subtly.

Thomas walks up to Sasha, camera in hand. He clicks a photo of the two of them in the mirror.

The shutter sound snaps Sasha out of her solitary moment, and she continues on with her day.

28 EXT. SASHA'S MEADOW - DAY

Sasha and Thomas get on their bikes and start pedalling through the meadow's dirt tracks.

Sasha leads the way smoothly, Thomas follows behind, wobbly and unpracticed.

THOMAS
They don't sell the stuff any closer?

Sasha looks back and laughs.

SASHA
No they do not. Think you'll make it?

They push their bikes up a steep hill. Thomas pushes the seat of Sasha's bike without her noticing, to make things a little easier.

They crest the hill, admire it for a moment, then coast down the other side.

29 EXT. TOWN - DAY

Sasha and Thomas pop in and out of shops, buying parts for the rocket. A few beams, a bag of screws, a thin flap of metal.

Sasha straps the pieces, wrapped in brown paper and twine, to both of their bikes.

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They set off, and cycle through the old fishing town.

30 EXT. PEBBLE BEACH - LATER THAT DAY

Sasha and Thomas lean their bikes against a tree. Thomas walks out towards the view. Sasha stops to look at a purple flower.

Thomas snaps a few pictures of the view.

THOMAS
(a little surprised)
It's beautiful.

Sasha is still focused on the flower.

SASHA
Look. *Nochnaya krasavitsa*. Isn’t it pretty? What do you call it in English?

Thomas doesn't peel his eye away from his viewfinder, aimed at the ocean.

THOMAS
This? It’s called the ocean. Isn’t that what you’re asking?

A beat from Sasha.

SASHA
The flower. Idiot.

She throws the insult without much conviction. Thomas feigns being wounded by her words, still looking through the camera.

Sasha almost laughs, but it catches just slightly on the way out.

Her eyes flick to the camera still hovering near his face, then back to him.

SASHA (CONT'D)
(quieter, half the laugh still in it)
You didn't even look.

He finally looks over at the flower, the camera still raised.

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THOMAS
I'm looking now.

SASHA
Now doesn't count.

He lowers the camera all the way, registering that he did something ever so slightly out of line. She holds the flower up properly, the moment already smoothing back over.

SASHA (CONT'D)
Nochnaya krasavitsa. Night beauty.

THOMAS
Totally. I was gonna say that.

SASHA
You were not.

THOMAS
I was not.

SASHA
What's it called in English?

THOMAS
Ooh, I've seen it before... Um... purple... purple something... purple crocus... no, like one of those-

SASHA
You don't know.

THOMAS
(crouching down properly, finally actually looking at it)
Okay, fine. Enlighten me then.

SASHA
(laughing genuinely)
I'm sorry! I'm sorry! Here-

She takes his hand and places the flower in it.

SASHA (CONT'D)
They only open in the evening.

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Thomas turns the flower over in his own fingers.

THOMAS
A four o'clock flower. My mother had these, in Toronto. It’s like they reach their apex every night around dinner time, like clockwork.

SASHA
(surprised, a bit of laughter left in her voice)
So you did know something.

THOMAS
(tapping his head)
Just needed a little jogging.

SASHA
Funny. We call them night beauties. They hide all day.

THOMAS
Maybe they're just waiting for the right light.

A beat.

She takes the flower and tucks it behind her ear, then walks out ahead of Thomas towards the shore.

Thomas snaps a few more photos of the lighthouse, then of her with her flower tucked behind her ear.

She just looks out to sea and the horizon. Thomas walks up behind her.

THOMAS (CONT'D)
Is that... it?

Across the water, a wooden chapel lists slightly, barely still standing.

SASHA
Yes.

THOMAS
I thought it'd be a little-

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SASHA
Bigger?

THOMAS
I didn't say that.

She smiles coyly at him.

THOMAS (CONT'D)
Is it even still open?

SASHA
Eh. Every second Sunday or something like that. But the lock is broken, so I suppose it's always open.

THOMAS
Looks old. A little flimsy.

SASHA
My grandmother used to take me here on Sundays. And every time she would she would tell me the story of why it looks so flimsy. When the Soviets came, churches like this weren't supposed to exist at all. So every three years, quietly, the whole congregation would take it apart themselves, and build it again from scratch a few hundred metres off.

THOMAS
Weird.

SASHA
A lot of wasted labour. But they believed it was a way to survive.

THOMAS
Why move it at all? Why not just leave it standing?

SASHA
If it never moved, it started to look like something worth confiscating.
(MORE)

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SASHA (CONT'D)
Or maybe they just wanted to make sure they could still build.

THOMAS
Did you ever see it? Being moved?

SASHA
No. By the time I was old enough to remember anything, the money for it was already gone, with everything else. Nobody could afford three years of tearing a church apart just to put it back together somewhere else.

THOMAS
So it just... stayed?

SASHA
It just stayed. First time in... I don't know. A hundred years, maybe more, that it hasn't moved.

A few moments of silence as they stand side by side, admiring the view. They hold hands as the waves crash around them.

SASHA (CONT'D)
Come on. We'll catch the train back.

31 INT. TRAIN - EVENING

Sasha and Thomas board the train as the light starts to go gold and low.

They park their bikes in a designated section in the train, then sit across from one another in an almost empty car.

On the seat next to Sasha, the rocket parts sit wrapped in brown paper and twine. They don't speak for a while.

The train pulls out, and Sasha turns to the window suddenly, taking in the landscape.

The fields start to move, slow at first, then faster, gold and green smudging into long unbroken bands of colour, fence posts ticking by like a metronome.

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Thomas watches Sasha watching. A camera sits in his lap, though he does not reach for it.

For a very long time, Sasha watches the countryside go by, and Thomas relaxes into the scenery smudged by speed.

Sasha looks over at Thomas, miraculously choosing exactly the moments where his own gaze drifts away from her.

SASHA
(looking outside)
When I was small, my grandmother and I used to take this line. She used to say you could tell how far away from Moscow you were by the way the dirt changed colour.

THOMAS
(turning to look outside)
It's red now. We must be far.

SASHA
Maybe. I can’t remember the sequence of colours, but there was an order to it. Brown and then orange and then this dark, dark red.

She taps against the window.

SASHA (CONT'D)
Around Arhengelsk it got all buried by snow anyway. Soil tones are not much use then.

A particularly loud screech booms from the tracks.

THOMAS
This train car's *old*.

SASHA
It's the same train car. The linoleum's still the same, and the rest of the insides too.

Sasha's face settles back into stillness. The train rattles and sways, and the two sit in silence.

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Outside, a woman waiting at a level crossing on a bicycle flashes by.

Sasha's eyelids get heavy. She fights it, sitting up straighter, blinking hard at the window. Finally, she gives in and her head tips slowly toward the glass.

Thomas watches this happen. A long beat.

Her breathing slows and evens out.

A strand of hair has fallen loose from behind her ear, lifting slightly with each small vibration of the train, catching light, brushing at the corner of her mouth.

Thomas gets up carefully, then crouches slightly at her side. He reaches out and brushes the hair back behind her ear, drinking in the moment.

His hand lingers half a second longer than the gesture requires.

She stirs slightly, not waking, just some small animal awareness of him near her. Without opening her eyes, she leans almost imperceptibly into the warmth of his hand.

He goes very still. Behind her sleeping head, the gold hour thins into the blue one. For a long time, Thomas crouches in the aisle, his knees complaining, his hand against her hair, watching the last of the light go.

32 INT. TRAIN - EVENING

Thomas has started to fall asleep too, and his hand slips gently from Sasha's face.

She jolts awake slightly, and looks out at the station they're stopped at.

Outside the window, Sasha sees a woman on a bike again.

START OF FLASHBACK

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33 EXT. TOWN - DAY

Sasha, almost a decade younger, rides her bicycle, the same one but less scuffed. Her hands don't have a hint of the grease and dirt they've accumulated in the present-day.

She rides aimlessly and seems to like it that way. She flies down a hill with no hands on the brakes, and glides through the sights and sounds of the Soviet Union alive and well.

She passes a group of students outside a café, papers and cheap beer on the table between them, someone reading something aloud that makes the whole table erupt. One of them calls her name, and she shouts back unintelligibly without slowing.

She climbs the hill beneath The Motherland Calls, and hops off her bike at the top before waiting for the wheels to stop turning.

She tumbles onto the grass in a heap of skirt and jacket and loose hair, breathless.

She lies back, and watches a smattering of small planes cross the sky.

Tracing their path with a finger, she mutters some private joke or story to herself inaudibly.

The engines drone, warmly and distant, providing a nice background hum.

For two short seconds, the sound shifts into something vaguely menacing. Her finger, pointed towards the sky, stills for moment. Then, the steady drone picks back up. Sasha relaxes once more and sits up.

She gets back on the bike and rides down the hill fast, reckless, whooping once, wordless, into the dark.

The lamplights, smear into golden, tungsten lines against the dark.

END OF FLASHBACK

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34 INT. TRAIN - EVENING

The train screeches to a halt. Through the window, Sasha sees the same amber lampposts, and looks slightly sad.

Thomas wakes and gives her a kiss on the forehead.

THOMAS
Let me help you with that.

He gathers their things, and they step off the train.

35 EXT. TRAIN STATION - EVENING

Sasha straps the rocket supplies to the sides of their bikes again.

It starts to rain, pulling muddied water to the hem of Sasha's sundress.

Thomas notices and pulls out an umbrella to hold it above her head.

He motions to her to hold it for a moment, and kneels to wring the brown water from her dress' hem.

She smiles down at him, her eyes so involved in the expression that they turn glassy.

He stands up again and takes the umbrella back, then catches her earnest smile.

She waddles towards him slightly and rest her forehead on his chest.

After taking it in for a few beats, he wraps his arms around her.

36 INT. THE BEDROOM - NIGHT

Thomas and Sasha lie side by side in their bed, fast asleep.

A slow zoom in grants access to their dreams.

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37 EXT. STOP-MOTION SET (DOLLHOUSE) - DAY

The dollhouse slowly comes together: first the bones, then the meat of the walls, then the furniture that fills the rooms.

The lights come on in each room, illuminating scenes of friends over for dinner and quiet moments spent in domestic bliss.

38 EXT. STOP-MOTION SET (MEADOW) - DAY

Day by day, the rocket comes together. The felt model of Sasha builds, the model of Thomas snaps pictures.

When the rocket is finished, both felt models climb in.

The background of the meadow fades to black until the only visible element is the finished rocket.

An orange glow erupts from beneath the rocket, propelling it into space.

39 INT. THE BEDROOM - NIGHT

Thomas turns over in his slumber and holds Sasha tight.

Their pyjamas morph into space suits. An orange glow is reflected in their helmets.

Across the glass of their helmets, tears roll from closed eyes.

40 EXT. STOP MOTION SET (SPACE) - NIGHT

The model of the rocket climbs higher and higher towards space. Eventually, it clears the upper atmosphere.

The door opens, and the two felt models float out into open space with waltz-like grace.

The felt model of Sasha pulls on the tether connecting her to Thomas, bringing him closer. She reaches out to hold his hand.

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The felt model of Thomas looks down at the Earth. It spins on itself, revealing all of its nooks and crannies, much to Thomas' delight.

He reaches towards it, but Sasha tightens her grip.

SASHA
(over a radio connecting them)
Don't let go.

He is surprised, but holds her close.

SASHA (CONT'D)
As a girl, I read that when they launched Sputnik an old scientist said that mankind would never remain bound to the Earth forever.

Thomas motions to them lightheartedly.

THOMAS
He's good.

SASHA
(more solemnly)
Nothing ever asked to be free from a mother.

A pause.

THOMAS
It's so small from up here. I haven't seen it like this before.

SASHA
You need a lot of bolts and time to see it like this.

The Earth, a tiny blue marble, morphs into Sasha's deep blue eye.

She pulls him closer and rests her head on his shoulder. After a few beats she looks up, like something very kind rests on the tip of her tongue.

THOMAS
I love you, Sasha.

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SASHA
I hope you mean it.

They float together in the vastness of space.

Suddenly, the tether is severed.

Sasha falls down to Earth as Thomas dangles helplessly up in space. Over the radio, she screams, the sound fading slowly into radio static, then to silence.

He tries to will his body to fight zero gravity and descend to Earth, but his efforts only bring him higher up.

He cuts his tether to the spaceship in hopes of being released back to Earth, but only floats higher yet.

His helmet pops clean off, and he starts to suffocate.

41 INT. BEDROOM - NIGHT

Thomas wakes from the dream in a state of heavy, silent hypoxia.

Shaken, he gets up quietly and exits.

42 EXT. SASHA'S MEADOW - NIGHT

Thomas sits beneath the apple tree. In the wet mud, he finds the tattered copy of *Leaves of Grass*.

He opens it at random like a bible, searching for guidance.

He reads a few lines aloud.

THOMAS
(raspy from the dream)
Afoot and lighthearted, I take to the open road. Healthy, free, the world before me. The long brown path before me, leading wherever I choose.

He swallows, forcing a deep breath into his belly.

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43 INT. BEDROOM - NIGHT

Sasha is still asleep.

THOMAS
(off screen, still reading)
Henceforth I ask not good fortune,
I myself am good fortune.
Henceforth I whimper no more,
postpone no more, need nothing.
Done with indoor complaints,
libraries, querulous criticisms,
Strong and content, I travel the
open road.

Sasha wakes and searches for Thomas in the bed, as though she expected him to be gone.

44 INT. KITCHEN - NIGHT

Sasha walks up to the door and sees him below the apple tree.

She grabs a snack and fixes some tea. When the tea's been brewed, she grabs an umbrella and heads out.

45 EXT. SASHA'S MEADOW - NIGHT

Sasha slowly walks up to Thomas. She sits next to him, and unwraps the food.

SASHA
Eat something. It'll make you feel better.

Thomas tastes the food, then bursts into tears. She holds him silently, looking up at the sky.

SASHA (CONT'D)
Look at that bright one up there, the star. That one doesn’t move. All the others turn around it, all night, every night. *Polyarna Zvezda*. Even on a night like this, so cloudy, you can see it. Even in Baikonur, in a whiteout, you could always find the one that stayed.

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THOMAS
Which one?

SASHA
Polaris. The engineers called it the ‘honest star.’ Every other star lies to you -- dies eventually, shifts or sets or disappears by morning. That one, though, doesn’t.

A long beat. Thomas looks back down at the ground.

THOMAS
I don't think I want anything to move ever again.

Sasha laughs and shakes her head. She spots the wet book, then picks it up.

SASHA
What are you reading?

He doesn't answer. She flips to a random page.

SASHA (CONT'D)
(reading from the page)
The earth, that is sufficient. I do not want the constellations any nearer. I know very well where they are. I know they suffice for those that belong to them. Still, here, I carry my old delicious burdens. I carry them, men and women, I carry them with me wherever I go. I swear it is impossible for me to get rid of them. I am fill’d with them, and I will fill them in return.

Thomas' head lands on Sasha's shoulder. He is fast asleep. Eventually, they both fall asleep beneath the tree.

46 EXT. SASHA'S MEADOW - DAY

Sasha wakes on the grass, alone. She looks out to the meadow, and sees Thomas standing before the water, looking out at the horizon.

She walks out to him.

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SASHA
I hope the propulsion system didn’t get too soaked last night in the downpour. It’s not fully water sealed yet.

Silence from Thomas, his gaze transfixed on the horizon.

SASHA (CONT'D)
Can you give me a hand, Thomas?

THOMAS
I'm not going anywhere.

SASHA
What? Come here.

He turns to look her dead in the eye.

THOMAS
Let’s fix the roof before the rains come back. Build you a shed behind the garden for the rocket. Plant the cabbages. Something to hold us through the winter.

A long beat.

THOMAS (CONT'D)
Can I stay?

He gets down on one knee, but isn't holding a ring. Sasha is stunned. For a split second her excitement bleeds through her regularly stoic demeanour.

She nods yes.

SASHA
The ground is wet today. You’re gonna need some better boots if you’re going to dig.

He rises to his feet, and they don't kiss or embrace. They just stand there, against the vast and empty meadow.

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ACT IV - THE ROCKET

47 INT. STOP MOTION SET (DOLLHOUSE) - DAY

The pair of felt models start on wedding preparations. They look at inspiration pictures sprawled out over a table. Sasha twirls with a little veil on.

INT. THOMAS' STUDIO - DAY

Thomas sits at his desk, hunched over felt and balsa, working on the dollhouse. Sasha drifts in behind him and kisses him on the top of the head.

She's wearing the sundress again, cleaned now. This time, it fits her in a way it never quite has before. Sasha drifts in behind him and kisses him on the top of the head.

SASHA
You've become disgustingly organised.

THOMAS
(not looking up)
I have a system now.

SASHA
You have a system.

THOMAS
I have a system, Sasha.

She peers over his shoulder at the half-built dollhouse — one room finished, walls up on the rest, roof half-shingled.

SASHA
Where do I go?

THOMAS
(pointing with the scalpel)
Kitchen. Obviously.

SASHA
Obviously.

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THOMAS
You're always doing something with your hands. Cooking, welding — same thing, basically.

SASHA
It is not the same thing.

THOMAS
It's the same energy.

She swats the back of his head lightly and settles into the armchair in the corner, cleared off now, unmistakably hers. She picks a scrap of paper off the side table and starts folding it without looking down at her hands.

A comfortable quiet. Thomas keeps working. Sasha keeps folding.

SASHA
There's a city with too many bridges. I read about it once.

THOMAS
(not looking up)
Which one?

SASHA
I don't know. I didn't look at the map. I just liked that you couldn't walk anywhere in a straight line. Every street just becomes a bridge eventually.

THOMAS
That's Amsterdam.

SASHA
I don't know that it's Amsterdam.

THOMAS
It's Amsterdam.

SASHA
(a little annoyed, a little amused)
Fine. Amsterdam.

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He sets the scalpel down, actually turning to look at her now.

THOMAS
What else?

SASHA
There's a coast somewhere. The water goes a colour they had a specific word for, not just blue. I've forgotten the word.

THOMAS
I could find out what the word is.

SASHA
That's not the point of telling you.

THOMAS
(leaning back, easy)
No, but I mean it. I've probably been near it. I could take you — bridges, the water, whatever the word is. Especially now, with Berlin —

Sasha's hands still on the fold, just barely. He doesn't catch it.

SASHA
You say that like it's small. Buying a ticket.

THOMAS
It kind of is.

SASHA
(flat)
Sure.

THOMAS
I'm serious. That's the whole benefit of having gone somewhere already. Second time, you bring someone.

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SASHA
(looking at him, almost fond, almost tired)
You think I want the bridges, Thomas.

THOMAS
Don't you?

SASHA
I want to have wanted them. That's different. That's the whole thing — something you fold on a Tuesday and never have to actually test against real weather.

THOMAS
That's very depressing, Sasha.

SASHA
It's very Russian.

She finishes the plane, one last crease, clearly a motion she's made a thousand times in her head even if this is the first time with paper this good. She holds it up, not to him, but to the little cracked mirror leaning against the wall behind his desk.

For a second her reflection gives her back something he's never once managed to catch directly, a girl, years younger, delighted by nothing more complicated than a piece of paper.

She laughs, surprised out of herself.

SASHA (CONT'D)
(to the mirror)
Look at you.

She sends the plane sailing across the room. It clips the drying line of negatives and spirals down near the door. She goes after it barefoot, laughing, half-dancing to catch it before it lands.

Thomas watches her — half out of his chair, scalpel forgotten in his hand.

She throws it again. It wobbles, arcs, and crash-lands directly into the dollhouse's unfinished room — the one with no bed yet.

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SASHA (CONT'D)
(delighted)
See? It knew exactly where to go.

THOMAS
I'll build the bed around it.

SASHA
Don't be sentimental.

THOMAS
Little late for that.

She crosses back to him, looks down at the tiny paper plane sitting in the unfinished room, then back up at him — something quieter now under the teasing.

SASHA
Don't build me a house I have to live up to.

He doesn't have a clever answer for that one. He just takes her hand.

A beat. Then, brisk again, she straightens up, already business.

SASHA (CONT'D)
Epoxy's setting. I have to go back.

She kisses him on the forehead, quick, familiar, and heads for the door, pulling the overalls off the hook without breaking stride.

He gets up, grabs the camera off the desk, and follows her out.

The paper plane stays behind in the dollhouse, small and white against the bare wood.

EXT. SASHA'S MEADOW - DAY

Sasha's rocket continues to come together. Thomas takes photos of her as she works, documenting the progress.

She starts to get irritated by the constant clicks of the camera. Thomas steps too close to her as she works.

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SASHA (CONT'D)
Don't get so close. This can burn you.

Thomas steps back cautiously and lowers the camera. He turns to go back to his studio, but stops and turns around. He crouches behind Sasha and hugs her at the waist.

The blowtorch burns him slightly, and he flinches. She slaps him across the arm.

SASHA (CONT'D)
I told you!

Thomas shakes it off and holds her anyways. She presses her head against his neck.

After a few beats, she goes back to work while Thomas watches from over her shoulder.

Sasha picks up a few feet of rubber hose to connect to the fuel assembly. She shakes Thomas off to work with more mobility.

THOMAS
What's this piece?

SASHA
It’s the fuel hose. Feeds the second stage of the propulsion mechanism. If it doesn’t hold, nothing else matters.

She pulls on the hose twice to test it's strength.

SASHA (CONT'D)
Back up a bit. I need some room.

She steps back from the rocket and pulls on the fuel hose, practiced and masterful.

As she pulls on the hose, Thomas is taken back to his dream.

START OF FLASHBACK

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48 EXT. STOP MOTION SET (SPACE) - NIGHT

The felt model of Sasha pulls on the tether. It snaps, and she falls back to Earth.

END OF FLASHBACK

49 EXT. SASHA'S MEADOW - MOMENTS LATER

Thomas jumps a little. Sasha is too focused on the work to notice anything is off.

He starts walking back to the studio, but retreats to give Sasha a kiss on the forehead.

50 INT. THOMAS' STUDIO - DAY

Thomas develops film in tanks. The negatives are hung all over the room to dry.

As they dry, photos of the rocket and the propulsion assembly emerges in the prints.

51 EXT. ROOF OF THE HOUSE - LATER

On the roof of the house, Sasha works on water sealing it in preparation for the next storm.

Thomas walks up to the ladder propped up against the side of the house.

He snaps a photo of her working on the roof.

THOMAS
You're so high up.

Sasha snickers - obviously.

THOMAS (CONT'D)
Be careful please.

SASHA
I know.

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THOMAS
(with sudden anxiety)
No, I'm serious!

Alarmed by the panic in his voice, Sasha stops what she's doing.

SASHA
What is it? Tell me.

THOMAS
Nothing, I'm just making sure you're safe.

SASHA
You tell me, or I come down.

THOMAS
No, it's okay-

Sasha slams down her nail gun and steps backwards, but slips and slides off the roof and into a bush.

Thomas lunges forward to catch her, but misses.

Sasha curses in Russian, but gets up and dusts herself off. She's okay, only irritated.

Thomas rushes to her side, worried ill.

SASHA
I'm fine. I'm fine. Old boots.

THOMAS
I'm bringing you to the hospital!

Sasha laughs.

SASHA
Hospital! In Russia! The postal service doesn't work. We're not driving four hours for a little bruise. I'm fine.

52 INT. BEDROOM - NIGHT

Thomas lies awake in bed. Unable to sleep, he wanders out of the room.

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53 INT. THOMAS' STUDIO - MOMENTS LATER

At his desk, Thomas goes through scattered mail. He finds a letter from a gallery in Berlin.

From a clothing line above his desk, he takes down a few developed pictures of the rocket.

He starts writing.

54 EXT. SASHA'S MEADOW - DAY

Thomas and Sasha walk through the meadow routinely.

Sasha pauses to clutch her leg.

THOMAS
Are you okay?

SASHA
(wincing)
I'm okay.

Thomas walks over to her and picks her up onto his back. She resists initially and laughs, but eventually slumps over his back and lets herself be carried.

SASHA (CONT'D)
I should fall more often. I didn't know the perks.

Thomas laughs. They walk a few more steps.

THOMAS
Oh, good news! I sent some photos of your work to a gallery in Berlin and they loved it. I think it'll be open to the public tomorrow-

Sasha goes very still and hops off of his back.

SASHA
You sent photographs of the rocket?

THOMAS
-or maybe after tomorrow? Not sure, but the curator said soon.

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Sasha looks at him, betrayed.

THOMAS (CONT'D)
What? It's important work, Sasha. People should see it.

She doesn't speak, and continues to stare at him furiously.

THOMAS (CONT'D)
And you can see Berlin, and London, and maybe even America, if those galleries take it. We can get you a doctor for your back. And you can see the world.

SASHA
(angry)
You are so-

She halts, trying to find the words. She mutters a few options in Russian, but fails to translate them.

SASHA (CONT'D)
You asked to stay.

She points to her ring finger.

THOMAS
Yes, Sasha, we can always come back. But right now you need a doctor, and someone in the West will recognize your work. No one can see how beautiful it is in this field.

SASHA
Beautiful is not a passport here.

55 EXT. THE HOUSE - DAY

The following days, officers armed with assault riffles and few words show up at their door. They are dressed more like mafia men wearing impressions of military garb, as officials did in the '90s in Russia.

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56 INT. THOMAS' STUDIO - DAY

The officers pocket all of the pictures of the rocket and Sasha's schematics.

57 EXT. SASHA'S MEADOW - DAY

The officers pull apart the pieces of Sasha's rocket, smashing it with the butts of their rifles, and the flat efficiency of men doing administrative work.

Thomas screams at them to stop, but jumps when the JUNIOR OFFICER lunges at him slightly. The officer laughs to himself.

Sasha flinches at each crack. She's devastated, but she won't show it when the State is present.

One of the officers starts to load pieces of the rocket onto the truck, but his commanding officer stops him.

COMMANDING OFFICER
(in Russian)
Put that down. It's just garbage.

JUNIOR OFFICER
(in Russian)
It looks important.

COMMANDING OFFICER
Just scrap metal. Go in the house and search there. Help yourself.

The junior officer ransacks the studio and leaves with a few valuables. Thomas tries to insert himself, but the officer continues unfazed.

They stand in the field and watch the truck leave.

She keels over from the shock, stoic and solemn, but deeply devastated. In the golden grass, peppered with nuggets of scrap metal, she collapses.

58 EXT. SASHA'S MEADOW - NIGHT

Sasha and Thomas look out at the moonlit water.

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THOMAS
I was trying to help you-

SASHA
When this is over, you can go home.
You can go *anywhere*.

He has no answer to this.

SASHA (CONT'D)
How lovely.

Sasha leaves Thomas standing alone in the endless midnight blue. He stares back out at the horizon.

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ACT V - THE DOLLHOUSE

59 INT. THOMAS' STUDIO - NIGHT

Some weeks have passed. Thomas and Sasha shelter away in the studio. The television can be heard blaring from the corner, advising citizens to shelter-in-place.

Outside, though, there are no missiles to be seen. Everything is uncannily peaceful.

Sasha leans back on her chair, her stoic look as always, but behind her eyes, a glean of absolute terror.

She fiddles with her Zippo lighter, like a nervous tick.

Thomas paces around the studio, muttering to himself.

THOMAS
What did those men want with the photographs? And the plans? For what?

SASHA
Who knows? It's never good.

THOMAS
They never took the rocket, though.

Sasha opens her mouth to say something, but stops herself. A tear wells in her eye, but she shakes it off.

Thomas is too busy pacing around to notice. A beat.

SASHA
They might as well have. It's in pieces.

THOMAS
It doesn't matter. We'll just buy some more steel. I'll-- I'll cable my bank in London and transfer the funds. We'll-- we'll make it so they *can't* destroy it next time. They have no right. Or-

Thomas puts his hands on Sasha's shoulders.

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THOMAS (CONT'D)
-or we'll call the embassy. Sasha, they will help us, they will. Just come with me, I'll get us out of here.

Sasha looks into Thomas' eyes for a beat, sincerely trying to search for some compassion in them.

Then, all the tears come out at once. She pounds on his chest while crying, then shoves him away, hard.

Thomas yelps in pain. He pulls away, sincerely confused. Sasha continues to hit him until her punches become slower and lighter from exhaustion.

Thomas kneels down to Sasha's level as she cries. He looks like he's about to say something vaguely apologetic.

Then, from the corner of the studio, an old television whirs up and starts blaring cold buzzer tones.

Thomas gets up and walks to the television, while Sasha remains on the ground. Her sobbing has stopped.

The television flickers violently, casting strobes on their faces. In Russian, we hear a cold, robotic voice.

TELEVISION (V.O.)
ATTENTION. This is an emergency alert. On 3 June, 1992, a nuclear strike was conducted in Western Europe. The great powers of the world are now at war. To ensure our continued safety and security, the Russian Federation is prepared to use a new space-grade nuclear weapon, propelled by old Soviet rocket technology.

Sasha's breathing gets heavier. Her spaceship. Something else now. A different name, a different destination.

TELEVISION (V.O.) (CONT'D)
It is capable of reaching Western Europe and the United States, and eliminating any possible threat to the Russian people.

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Thomas puts his hand to his mouth. He starts to weep from the shock.

TELEVISION (V.O.) (CONT'D)
Every responsible citizen is expected to react with courage. Order and discipline will help us in our efforts to re-establish peace. The greatest enemy amongst us now is fear itself. There is no safer place in the world than where we are now. Keep calm. We will win.

The television goes dark. Thomas falls to the ground and weeps, helplessly. Sasha rises, shocked at how fast his reactions changed.

She rises from her spot and walks right past Thomas and out of the door. She turns back to look at him flayed out on the ground, shooting him a look of disgust.

He doesn't even look up at her.

Then, she gets on her bicycle and rides off into the dark.

60 EXT. OLD ORTHODOX CATHEDRAL - NIGHT

Sasha crests the hill near the Cape and rides down to the cathedral. She props her bike against the doors and enters.

With her Zippo lighter, she lights a candle and holds it in front of her, then lights a whole case of them. She stares at the icons for a moment. Then, she walks up and kneels before the altar.

She glances around sheepishly, as though she was doing something wrong. Her faith isn't yet there. She can't yet find it.

She closes her eyes, then looks up to the cross. She wishes she could believe in Thomas' magic now. That she can change her fate.

Frustrated, she sighs sharply and stares at the cross, now angry.

SASHA
Show yourself, coward.

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A beat. Then she recites the Lord's Prayer, spitefully for the first few sentences, then slower, as though she's reached something.

SASHA (CONT'D)
Our Father, who art in Heaven, hallowed be Thy name. Thy kingdom come, Thy will be done, on Earth as it is in Heaven. Give us this day our daily bread, and forgive us our trespasses, as we forgive those-

She stops herself. There's no time. Tears now well in her eyes, and she begs, crudely, absent the eloquence of someone who prays often.

SASHA (CONT'D)
Please save us, Lord, please, please please- I would do anything- anything- why would you do this to us- it's so cruel, so, so cruel- but you must have a reason, so please, please spare us, me, and Thomas, and our house and our cabbages and our garden and our meadow and our water and our bicycles and our trains and our purple flowers and our dark, ugly, red, dirt. I would do anything. I- I- will believe in you, I wish I could, I wish I could believe in you. I will do anything, *anything*.

She grabs the edge of the altar hard.

SASHA (CONT'D)
You want something? Take it. Take it all. Just stop this. Undo it. Undo what they built.

A desperate, ragged breath.

SASHA (CONT'D)
I'll give you the rocket, all the pieces of it. Every bolt, every sheet of aluminum, every drawing under the floorboards. I won't rebuild it ever again.

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She freezes. A tear finally breaks. Her voice drops from shouting to a confession.

SASHA (CONT'D)
Like it was ever going to fly. You knew that. It was never going to get me out of here.

Sasha surprises herself. She comes to a realization.

CUT TO:

61 EXT. SASHA'S MEADOW - NIGHT

Wordlessly, Sasha gathers the remaining pieces of her rocket and douses them in lighter fluid.

She sets all that remains of her work on fire. A look of utter shock strikes her face, as if to say, if only for a moment: 'What have I done?'

She reaches instinctively for a nearby bucket to fetch some water, but stops herself. The fires flicker in her irises, then against her skin, casting her calloused hands in bright, flickering orange. Then, she walks away and lets it burn into the night.

62 INT. BEDROOM - NIGHT

Sasha enters their bedroom. Thomas, seated by the window, stares longingly out to the water, its surface glittering in the moonlight, his face illuminated by streaks of moonlight.

He doesn't turn when she enters. His eyes stay on the water, and on whatever is out past it — the horizon, or something further than that.

THOMAS
(quietly, almost to himself)
Funny thing about the bomb. Nobody ever actually sees it coming. Not really. You just get a broadcast.
(MORE)

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THOMAS (CONT'D)
A man's voice on a television, telling you the world's already changed, past tense, before you've even had the chance to watch it happen.

Sasha doesn't answer. She doesn't acknowledge him at all.

THOMAS (CONT'D)
I keep waiting to feel something bigger than this. But it's just water. Same water as always. A war is on, and yet nothing's really changed, has it?

Thomas turns over to her, as if to check if she's still angry, then stares back out to the water.

Sasha crosses to the bed without a word and lies down, facing away from him.

Some time later. Thomas and Sasha lay on opposite sides of the bed.

We zoom, this time gaining access to Sasha's dreams.

EXT. SPACE DREAM - NIGHT

Sasha is in her spacesuit, drifting. Thomas is tethered to her. They are back in Thomas' spaceflight dream from before, except this time rendered in live action. From behind their helmets, they gaze into each other's eyes.

THOMAS (CONT'D)
I love you.

She smiles, and believes him. They embrace.

For a long moment neither of them says anything. The Earth turns slowly beneath them, blue and small and very far away.

SASHA
I made a promise.

THOMAS
To who?

SASHA
Someone I don't usually talk to.

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Thomas laughs a little, not understanding yet, still holding her.

THOMAS
What kind of promise?

SASHA
I told him I'd give it all back, the rocket. Every bolt of it.

THOMAS
Give it back to who? Sasha, none of that's yours to give anymore. They took it.

SASHA
I didn't say the rocket in the field, Thomas.

He goes still. She pulls back slightly, just enough to look at him properly through the glass of her helmet.

SASHA (CONT'D)
I said I'd stop reaching for it. The bridges, the flying, the leaving. I told him I'd trade it, if he'd just make this stop.

THOMAS
That's not how it works. You can't bargain your way out of a war.

SASHA
I know that now.

She looks past him, higher, past the stars.

SASHA (CONT'D)
Everyone always said He was up here. Past the clouds. Past the blue part.

THOMAS
Sasha.

SASHA
We came all this way. Look how far we came.

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She looks around them, at the dark, at nothing.

SASHA (CONT'D)
It's just more dark.

THOMAS
Then let's leave. Both of us. Cut the whole thing loose — the country, the war, whatever's pulling at you up here. We don't have to stay tethered to any of it.

SASHA
You say that like the tether's optional. Like I could just decide not to be from anywhere.

THOMAS
You could decide to be from somewhere else. People do it.

SASHA
Not people like me. I've spent my whole life being pulled back down to the exact same patch of dirt no matter how far I got. Every time I think I'm floating I look down and I'm still tethered to something.

THOMAS
Then cut it. That's what the knife's for, isn't it? Cut it and come with me instead.

Something in her face shifts, like she's already three steps past the conversation he thinks they're having.

SASHA
You still don't understand what the tether's holding onto.

She reaches up and rests her gloved hand against the glass of his helmet, over where his cheek would be.

SASHA (CONT'D)
You get to go home, Thomas. That was always true, from the very first day.
(MORE)

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SASHA (CONT'D)
So if one of us has to be pulled back down, it was always going to be me.

THOMAS
I don't want you to be pulled back down. I want you to fight it. Whatever it is. Fight it with me.

SASHA
You still think this is a thing you fight?

THOMAS
Everything's a thing you fight. That's the whole point of being alive.

SASHA
I wish I could think like that. But gravity doesn't lose.

Beat.

SASHA (CONT'D)
(pointing at the stars)
He doesn't lose either. I've tried arguing with both of them. They're patient in the exact same way.

She looks up once, into the stars.

SASHA (CONT'D)
(to the skies)
You're not even up here, are You. I thought You would be. Everyone always said You would be.

Nothing answers. Not even static.

SASHA (CONT'D)
That's alright. I don't think I came looking for You anyway.

Thomas shakes his head, uncomprehending, panic starting to surface underneath his certainty.

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THOMAS
Please. Don't do this. Whatever this is, don't.

SASHA
I already did it, in the church. I'm just finishing it now.

She reaches down and unhooks a small pocket on her spacesuit. From it she draws a small knife, and spins it once in her hand, unhurried, the way she'd handle any tool she trusts completely.

THOMAS
Sasha I love you-

SASHA
(over him, calm)
God, I hope that you mean it.

THOMAS
Of course I do.

She looks up once more, back at the stars.

SASHA
(quiet, almost tender)
There. Take it. That's the last of it.

She looks back at Thomas.

SASHA (CONT'D)
Then let me finish what I started.

He tries to grab for her hand, for the knife, for anything, but she's already moving. She cuts the tether.

THOMAS
(shouting)
Sasha-

His voice tears out of him, but there's no sound to carry it, only the radio crackle and then nothing at all.

She falls back into the atmosphere, burning alive and screaming from her gut.

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But she does not fall alone, and she does not fall blind. Still in her suit, still tethered to nothing, she is present inside every memory that follows, not remembering it from a distance, but standing inside it, watching, as though each one is being handed to her only so she can watch it be taken away again.

START OF DREAM 1

EXT. THE CAPE - DAY

Young Sasha (12) holds onto her grandmother's hand, looking onto the same chapel she'd explained to Thomas.

Behind them, half-hidden in the long grass at the edge of the frame, SASHA in her spacesuit watches. Her younger self doesn't see her. Nobody in the memory ever will.

SASHA'S GRANDMOTHER
-and then plank by plank, they take it all apart.

Young Sasha cocks her head.

SASHA
Looks okay to me.

SASHA'S GRANDMOTHER
Well that brings me to the next part, dear.

Unintelligibly, we see Sasha's grandmother explain the process of rebuilding as Young Sasha looks out at the chapel.

We see the chapel briefly reflected in her iris.

Over the mumble of her grandmother's explanations, the chapel glitches between a pile of planks and a fully rebuilt structure. With each glitch, it appears in a different spot on the cape.

SASHA'S GRANDMOTHER (CONT'D)
-And then it is ours again. It is ours there, there, there and there. And more so with each time it moves.

END OF DREAM 1

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START OF DREAM 2

EXT. TOWN - DAY

In her university years, Sasha bikes through the town again. This time, her ride is not so smooth and uninhibited.

Sasha, in her spacesuit, stands at the base of the hill, watching her younger self struggle upward, unable to reach her, unable to do anything but witness.

She pedals a few cycles before falling, again and again. Each time she falls, she forces herself back up with increasing desperation, like her magic is fading from her with each passing push.

After painstakingly reaching the top of the hill, she looks onto the city.

In similar glitches to the chapel dismembered and rebuilt, parts of the city catch on fire.

The sound of planes come back, roaring with the same cadence that had unsettled her for a mere few seconds in the earlier flashback. Armageddon is here.

Explosions are reflected in her eyes — both of her, the young woman on the bicycle and the woman in the spacesuit standing below, watching the same fire find the same city twice.

END OF DREAM 2

START OF DREAM 3

EXT. BAIKONUR COSMODROME - DAY

An enormous field spreads out under an endless horizon.

Sasha stands alone in the grass, spacesuit catching the light.

The rocket goes bright, blinding white — not a launch, not really, more like the moment before a photograph develops, everything dissolving into light before it can resolve into ruin.

END OF DREAM 3

EXT. THE MEADOW - DAY

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As Sasha finishes her fiery descent, miraculously, the fire stops.

From white, she's back in the meadow in her spacesuit, whole, untouched.

Beside her the dollhouse sits open, room by room, and she watches herself through the glass of her helmet the way you'd watch something through a window you can't open.

In the dollhouse she sees the felt figures cooking, cleaning, the small ordinary motions of a life they might have had, foreclosed now, but entirely visible. The birds are still going. Somewhere, far off, a train. She stands. She breathes.

Then day cuts to night in a single stroke.

A siren rings out, full in the mix and with the same cold, robotic cadence of the emergency broadcast, except now it has no voice attached to it and no news left to deliver.

INT. BEDROOM - NIGHT

Sasha wakes to the sound of sirens and runs outside. Thomas follows a few seconds later.

EXT. MEADOW - NIGHT

The sacrifice changed nothing. The bombs were always going to fall, and nothing she did or didn't do was ever going to be the variable. Complete black, except Sasha lit only in pulses of red, once, twice, three times, then swallowed by dark again.

On the fourth, longer than the rest, the silhouettes of planes assemble overhead into formation, and then the sky opens.

In the sky, a hauntingly beautiful formation of war planes zoom through at breakneck speed.

Sasha falls to her knees and closes her eyes, ripping off her helmet and pressing her hand against the sides of her head. Thomas comes running to hold her.

CUT TO BLACK

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63 EXT. SASHA'S MEADOW - DAY

Some time later. The two walk back to what remains of the house.

Thomas takes pictures, with the urgency of someone who believes insurance proof will suffice to remedy the damage.

Sasha pulls away from Thomas.

She approaches the dollhouse still sitting in the field, her fist raised.

Thomas runs over to hold her back, but she falls to her knees before it before he can.

She pulls apart the tiny door, then the roof and pops the windows out.

Confused by the mismatch between her air of violence and her too careful destruction, Thomas protests gently at first.

Sasha starts to pull apart the walls and floorboards, turning the dollhouse into a pile of materials.

Thomas starts to panic as the destruction grows slow but steady.

He falls to his knees and clutches his camera, and cries. She stands, looking on, crying but subdued, as though she expected it all along.

She gathers the pieces of the dollhouse in her arms and walks a few steps before dropping them back down again.

She starts piecing the dollhouse together again for a few beats.

Spotting Thomas' camera by his side, she makes a lunge for it. She catches the strap of it as Thomas grips onto the body. They tug-of-war for a second before Thomas lets go in hopes of using his words.

THOMAS
If I lose the camera, I lose -

He motions to the two of them.

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THOMAS (CONT'D)
Us.

SASHA
(holding up the camera)
That's not us. That's just you, holding still for 1/100th of a second.

Sasha looks at the camera in her hands. She doesn't smash it. She looks at him, really looks at him.

She steps back and opens the film door, pulling the film out and exposing it to the moonlight. We see the silver ribbon of the film fogging over. He looks on, shocked into stillness.

She hands the dead camera back to him. It's no longer a record, just an object. Thomas looks at it, and for the first time, he doesn't feel the need to check the settings. He sets it down on the floor between them. It's a marker, like a headstone for the dream they shared.

He reaches out and touches her face to feel the warmth of her skin. She leans into his hand for a brief, fleeting second. A moment of pure, unrecorded connection.

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ACT VI - THE MATCHSTICKS

NOTE FOR REVIEWERS:

We are workshopping CONTRADANCE's ending, and playing around with lots of ideas. Parts of this section, marked by '// BEGIN TREATMENT' and END TREATMENT //' still exists in treatment form, rather than locked scene blocking.

The emotional and thematic payoff of these sequences is settled: what we're still testing is the exact visual mechanism (dream structure, VFX load, pacing of the vision/siren sequences) before committing to scene-level detail, particularly given our commitment to a true micro-budget shoot. We didn't want to lock blocking prematurely on sequences this ambitious before we've fully reconciled vision with what we can actually achieve in-camera.

EXT. DOCK - DAY

THOMAS stands with a bag at his feet, the dead camera still around his neck out of habit.

Gulls wheel overhead. Somewhere behind him, a rope creaks against a piling.

He looks back once. Not at her — she's not there. Just at the town, the flat grey sky, the dull gold of the domes in the distance, smaller now than they've ever looked.

He shifts the bag onto his shoulder and doesn't look back again.

INT. BORDER CHECKPOINT - DAY

A blue Western passport is cleanly stamped by an immigration official. The stamp comes down hard, indifferent, the same motion repeated a thousand times a day for a thousand other people.

Thomas stands at the checkpoint, hollowed out. Beside him, heavy aluminum equipment cases wrapped in duct tape. Someone else in line eyes the cases, then looks away.

He walks past the gates with the effortless immunity of his citizenship: nobody stops him, nobody searches the cases twice, the whole apparatus of the border simply parting for him the way it always has.

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He has the privilege to leave the disaster zone he helped trigger. She doesn't have an exit visa. She has to do the hard work of staying.

INT. TRAIN - DAY

Thomas takes a seat by the window, looking out. The car is emptier than it should be. A few other passengers, faces turned away. Nobody making conversation.

Another train passes, close enough that for a few seconds the two cars run parallel. Glimpses into each cabin, like windows of the dollhouse, except now each frame holds people escaping the war — hands on foreheads, holding each other, unsure what to do, a child asleep against a stranger's shoulder, a man staring at nothing. He's heading in the opposite direction. The other train pulls ahead and is gone.

As his own train pulls away from the next stop, his window centres on a girl with blonde hair facing away from the platform, framed by the black borders of the glass, the same way he first saw Sasha. For a moment he thinks it's her.

His hand moves toward the glass before he stops it. She turns her head halfway, but the train pulls away, and he never gets a good look. It probably isn't her. But in that slight chance, he will simply never know.

He sits there for a long time. The destruction and the beauty of the land pass by outside — a burned field here, an untouched orchard there, a church steeple still standing beside a collapsed roofline — and he passes through all of it, emotionless, no objective, no conflict. Just space, and distance, and the sense that he's being condemned to both.

The light changes outside, gold sliding toward grey. His hands stay folded in his lap the whole way.

EXT. FERRY - DAY

Thomas boards. The Statue of Liberty appears through the window, right side up.

The shot spins a hundred and eighty degrees. The statue now sits upside down, yet a zoom-out reveals Thomas right side up at the window.

He watches the view, now flipped upside down.

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INT. CHAPEL - DAY

Some time has passed.

Sasha sits alone in the pews, looking up through the stained glass.

Dust turns slowly in the coloured light falling across her hands. She doesn't move for a long while.

EXT. THE MEADOW - NIGHT

Intercut with the chapel: SASHA, alone in the moonlit meadow. She walks out deeper and deeper into the dark water, her nightdress dragging heavy against her legs.

Rapid intercuts — Jesus in the stained glass, then a microscope, then the glass again. The dollhouse. The rocket morphing into a missile. The ashes. The fire. The microscope, then Jesus again. Sasha in the water, waves crashing at her ankles. Jesus once more. The moon. The clouds. The stars. The water, moonlight glistening across it. The fire and the ashes. The blast site. The mushroom cloud.

She closes her eyes.

INT. CHAPEL - NIGHT

From exhaustion, she collapses onto the ruined pew. She lies back and reaches her right arm up into the air, as though holding it out for God.

Her fingers stay open. Waiting for something to fill them.

EXT. THE MEADOW - NIGHT

She walks further into the water. Sits. Defeated. She picks up sand and holds it in her hands as the waves slowly take her.

She falls backward. Top-down, the water rolls, sending her hair floating outward, dark against the pale sand below.

A few beats. Then she raises her right hand up to the sky and the moon, the same as in the pew.

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Harsh intercuts between the two — the water and the church floor, Sasha wrangling in both, searching, struggling, her body pulling against something in each place that won't quite let her go and won't quite hold her either.

But after some time, she is slowly lifted.

The Buran is there, in the endless dark just after dusk. It is not arriving, exactly. It was always already there — the way a theorem is true before anyone writes it down, the way stars are burning before anyone names them. It did not need the launch. It did not need the officers to stay away. It did not need Thomas.

That great steel mass coalesced into everything it was meant to be, everything it never was, and it drifts there, weightless, unhurried, above the ruin and the ash and the battered provinces and the end of all their dreaming. It is not striving anymore, because striving was always beside the point. The work was the point. The cold was the point. The bolt turned in the dark, the callous forming on the palm, the grease under the fingernail — that was the point. She was always already there, in every hour she spent in that meadow, and no one can administer that away. No one can load it into the back of a truck.

She watches it drift past the moon, weightless in the upper atmosphere, despite the ruin, despite the sorrow and the horror and the trickery and the disappointment.

Her outstretched arm falls slowly to her side. She is not at peace, exactly. She is returned to herself. To the thing she always knew, before Thomas, before the camera, before anyone needed her to be evidence of anything. That the thing you build with your hands is not a means to something else. It is the thing itself. It was always only ever the thing itself.

Straight to black.

INT. CHAPEL - DAY

Beneath the golden light shining in, SASHA opens her eyes. The altar and the smoke. She rises, leaves the chapel, and gets back on her bike.

EXT. THE MEADOW - DAY

She rides out past the meadow, now in daylight, revealing the full desolation of the strike. Just her now.

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She walks up to the ruined house and stands before it for a long time. Her hand finds the doorframe, still standing though the door itself is gone.

Then she walks to where the tree was. Completely destroyed — blackened, collapsed, gone. But beside it, another small tree, still wrapped in plastic at the roots. She looks at it. No doubt thinking of Thomas.

After a while, silently, she picks up her shovel and starts digging.

INT. STOP-MOTION STAGE - DAY

The camera sits in front of the pile of ashes and the pieces of the projector. A slow dolly out, then a track right. The background changes.

SASHA's hands enter frame. She starts building a house of matchsticks, one at a time, unhurried, as though she has all the time in the world now, which, in a way, she does.

Holst's Chaconne bass returns here, creeping in beneath it all.

Hold on her hands, and the two pieces of wood, alone on the empty stage.

END CARDS, OVER BLACK.

For those who build what cannot last.

END TREATMENT //

64